

The violent death of Valentinian III, one year after that of Aetius, constitutes an important turning point in the history of the Roman West¹. It marks the end of the late antique dynastic empire and proclaims the crisis of relations between the monarchy and military commands. The immediate effect was a further hardening of relations with the *pars Orientis*² and a renewed aggressiveness of the Germanic populations installed in the Roman provinces³. The isolation and vulnerability of Rome in turn accentuated the climate of instability in internal relations that had already manifested itself in the age of Stilicho.

- 1 1. 1 The rupture is highlighted by Marcellinus (chron. a. 454): Aetius magna Occidentalis rei publicae salus et regi Attilae terror a Valentiniano imperatore cum Boethio amico in palatio trucidatur, atque cum ipso Hesperium cecidit regnum nec hactenus valuit relevari. On this passage, cf. B. Croke, *The Chronicle of Marcellinus. A Translation with Commentary*, Leiden-Boston 1995, 93; M. Kruse, *The Politics of Roman Memory. From the Fall of the Western Empire to the Age of Justinian*, Philadelphia 2019, esp. 172-180.
- 2 2. 2 The signs of a crisis in relations between the two parts of the empire emerged when Attila asked Honoria for marriage (G. Zecchini, Aezio: l'ultima difesa dell'Occidente romano, Rome 1983, 264-266); these intensified in subsequent years, on the occasion of Marcian's nomination (V. Baini, Per una nuova interpretazione del regno di Marciano, *MediterrAnt*, 7 [2004], 373-405: 390-391). Marcian and Leo, on the other hand, do not seem to have played any role in the events of the *pars Occidentis* after 455, where all imperial appointments, up to 467, were the result of the evolution of internal relations; cf. esp. J. Szidat, *Usurpator tanti nominis. Kaiser und Usurpator in der Spätantike (337-476 n. Chr.)*, Stuttgart 2010, 125-130; 283-286; 347-356 and passim; cf. also F. Oppedisano, *L'impero d'Occidente negli anni di Maioriano*, Rome 2013, 61-62; 73-74; 103-118; see also *infra*, chap. III.
- 3 3. 3 For a general overview of the crisis in relations between Rome and the barbarians and the profound changes marking diplomatic practices in this phase, see A. Becker, *Les relations diplomatiques romano-barbares en Occident au Ve siècle. Acteurs, fonctions, modalités*, Paris 2013, 64-82. The most serious episode for the history of the Western Empire was the breaking of treaties with the Vandals, which led to the sack of 455, and which ultimately derives from Petronius Maximus' attempt to legitimize his position by breaking the matrimonial promises, guaranteed by Valentinian III and Aetius, between the family of Gaiseric and the Theodosian dynasty: U. Roberto, *Roma capta. Il Sacco della città dai Galli al Lanzichenecchi*, Rome-Bari 2012, 145-146. An aggravation of the effects caused by the Vandal conquest of Africa is recorded (on the periodizing value of that event, cf. e.g. C. Wickham, *Framing the Early Middle Ages. Europe and the Mediterranean, 400-800*, Oxford 2005, 87-93); besides the increasingly frequent incursions of the Vandals on the coasts of southern Italy and Sicily (*infra*, chap. X), from 455 onwards, according to Savino, the supplies of the *res privata* to Rome ceased, with repercussions on urban demography; E. Savino, *La conquista vandalica dell'Africa e la popolazione di Roma nel V sec. d.C.*, *Athenaeum*, 107 (2019), 156-168; cf. J. Linn, *The Roman Grain Supply, 442-455*, *JLA*, 5 (2012), 298-321. For phenomena of «resilience» after 455, see M.R. Salzman, *Emperors and Elites in Rome after the Vandal Sack of 455*, *AntTard*, 25 (2017), 243-263.

FABRIZIO OPPEDISANO and that resulted in a weakening of imperial authority against the position of strength of the *magister militum praesentalis* and the senatorial aristocracy⁴. In the twenty-one years between the death of Valentinian III and the deposition of Romulus Augustulus, the government of Rome passed from one emperor to another nine times, with two long periods of interregnum (in 456-457, between the deposition of Avitus and the election of Majorian, and in 465-467, between the death of Libius Severus and the advent of Anthemius). The figure who, more than any other, was able to maintain a position of strength was Ricimer, who remained at the head of military commands for about sixteen years, until his natural death, which occurred under Olybrius in the summer of 4725. In this period of time, he outlived four emperors and, in at least three cases, was directly responsible for their deaths⁶. There is an impression of a role reversal: while the Roman emperor is unable to choose the military leaders of the *res publica*, a *magister militum* of Germanic origin dictates the rhythm of successions to the throne. The image of an imperial authority now worn out by the competition of the supreme commander of the army has taken root in modern historiography, sometimes in an excessively schematic way: in an empire close to collapse, the last Roman princes often assumed the guise of helpless puppets, manipulated in the shadows by their powerful general. There have been no clarifications aimed at softening or contrasting this representation, yet it has enjoyed wide fortune, which has fostered a largely indistinct view of the last Roman emperors of the West. Their profiles tend towards rarefaction and their personalities end up diluted in an amalgam of very distinct characteristics: weak, heteronomous, incapable of acting effectively in society and of countering the forces that threatened its integrity from outside, these drab epigones of the imperial tradition appear committed to reiterating the same failed experience, thus embodying the agony of Rome⁷.

- 1 1. 4 The transformation of the balance of power between the imperial government and the senatorial aristocracy in the years of Stilicho is one of the fundamental contributions of S. Mazzarino's first book, *Stilicho. The imperial crisis after Theodosius*, Milan 1990 (Rome 1942): F. Oppedisano, *Santo Mazzarino and the late antique senate*, *StudStor*, 61 (2020), 27-39.
- 2 2. 5 On Ricimer, see V. Anders, *Flavius Ricimer. Power and Impotence of the Western Roman Magister Militum in the second half of the 5th Century*, Frankfurt a. M.-Belin-Bern-Brussels-New York-Oxford 2010.
- 3 3. 6 On the death of Avitus and Majorian: Oppedisano, *The Empire of the West*, 81-90; 273-278; on the death of Anthemius: Roberto, *Roma capta*, 178-193; on Libius Severus: S.I. Oost, *D. N. Libius Severus P. F. Aug.*, *CPh*, 65 (1970), 228-240.
- 4 4. 7 In relation to the post-Theodosian West, the expression 'shadow-emperor' (*Schattenkaiser*) is used in early 19th-century German works to indicate specific figures, in particular Libius Severus, Glycerius and Romulus Augustulus. W. Menzen, *The History of the Germans*, I, *Time of Heathen Antiquity up to Charlemagne*, Zurich 1825, 157; F. Lorenz, *Occidental Empire*, in *General Encyclopedia of Sciences and Arts in alphabetical order*, edited and published by J.S. Ersch and J.G. Gruber, with Engravings and Charts, III, 1, edited by M.H.E. Meier and L.F. Kämiz, Leipzig 1830, 243-260: 251 and 252; A. Wilhelm, *Odoacer*, *ibid.*, 366-374: 368; L.M. Hartmann, *The Italian Kingdom*, I, Leipzig 1897, 43. The use of the word *fantôme* precedes: Libius Severus is defined as "the *fantôme d'Empereur* created by Ricimer" by J.-C. Royou, *History of the Lower Empire, since Constantine, up to the fall of Constantinople*, in 1453, I, Paris 1803, 524, while in the French edition of Gibbon's work, translated by M.F. Guizot in 1819, the expression "nominal reign" was rendered with "the reign of this *fantôme d'empereur*".

INTRODUCTION It is not easy to restore distinctive features to such figures, and in the most careful treatments of the concluding years of the Western Roman Empire, the need is often felt to associate with the names of the last emperors an epithet capable of distinguishing them from each other (Petronius Maximus is the noble, Avitus the Gallo-Roman, Majorian the military, Libius Severus the Lucanian, Anthemius the Greek)⁸, or to divide them by typology (emperors of senatorial origin, military men, child emperors)⁹. The only experience of government to which a certain importance has been frequently attributed is that of Majorian. However, it has been valued mainly for its eccentric character compared to the spirit of those years. Majorian seems to have interpreted his role as a tragic hero, stubbornly affirming the values of a Romanitas by now contaminated by barbarism, which had penetrated deep into the heart of imperial government. He wanted to act more like a Germanicus or a Trajan than a fifth-century monarch, and for this reason, his attempt to revive the fortunes of Rome, however courageous, was inevitably destined to fail¹⁰. In a vision that largely reflects the Justinianic perspective developed by Marcellinus and that tends to assume teleological nuances, the impact of 476 becomes minimal: the deposition of Romulus Augustulus is the natural outcome of the disintegration of imperial power that characterized the years following the death of Valentinian III, and the fortunate parabola of Ricimer is the prefiguration of the subsequent one, that of the Scirian Odoacer. In the internal periodizations of late antiquity, there emerges a tendency to group the two phases 455-476 and 476-493 into a single period of transition between the end of the Theodosians and the beginning of the Ostrogothic monarchy¹¹, during which, with the disintegration of the Roman political and institutional fabric, a new order is established, centered on the figure of a military leader of barbaric origin. Aspects in counter-tendency, political experiments, or failed attempts tend to remain on the margins of an evolutionary process that leads, in a linear fashion overall, from 455 to 476 and thus to 493. (E. Gibbon, *The History of the Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire*, IV, ed. J.B. Bury, London 1898 [1788-1789], 25). In T. Hodgkin, *Theodoric the Goth. Barbarian Champion of Civilization*, New York-London 1897, 96-97, 'shadow-emperors' is now comprehensively associated with the period 455-476 ("with the single exception of Majorian"). This is an important passage, because during the 20th century, these formulas became very widespread, especially in Anglophone historiography, both in the form of shadow emperors and in that of puppet emperors. The entrenchment of such expressions is such that even in works attentive to the specificities of these emperors, they are used to comprehensively indicate the last twenty years of the Western Roman Empire (see for example R.W. Mathisen, *De imperatoribus Romanis*. An Online Encyclopedia of Roman Emperors, <https://www.roman-emperors.org/libius.htm> [January 2020], where Libius Severus is «the fourth of the so-called 'shadow' or 'puppet' western emperors»), or the recent contribution by M. McEvoy, *Shadow Emperors and the Choices of Rome (455-476 AD)*, *AntTard*, 25 [2017], 95-112).

1 1. 8 See in particular D. Henning, *Periclitans res publica: Kaisertum und Eliten in der Krise des weströmischen Reiches 454/5-493 n. Chr.*, Stuttgart 1999.

2 2. 9 McEvoy, *Shadow Emperors*, whose classification appears arbitrary: if the senatorial profile of Petronius Maximus and Libius Severus, as well as the military profile of Majorian, seem to effectively characterize these emperors, it is not possible to affirm that Avitus and Anthemius were military men for the simple reason that they held military offices.

3 3. 10 For an examination of these problems, see Oppedisano, *L'impero d'Occidente*, 9-14.

4 4. 11 See e.g. A. Demandt, *Die Spätantike. Römische Geschichte von Diocletian bis Justinian, 284-565 n. Chr.*, Munich 2007 (1989), 204-217; Henning, *Periclitans res publica*.

Anthemius' experience does not escape this general vision, in fact, it confirms it: his origins and the role played by Leo in his nomination have been interpreted as evident signs of Rome's weakness, but at the same time they constitute the causes of the civil war of 472, as if the Roman West were by now spiraling into a condition that prevented it on one hand from autonomously confronting internal problems and external threats, and on the other hand from accepting the command of a *Graeculus* and the interference of the Byzantine East¹². An analytical study of Anthemius' figure and his politics – which in this book is carried out systematically and from a plurality of viewpoints for the first time – allows to outline a different picture, both of his role in Italy and of the balance of power within the *res publica* in the final decades of the Western Roman Empire. His ascent to the throne was not imposed by Constantinople – which, moreover, would not have been able to do so – but was the outcome of a convergence of interests: in the East, Leo was ridding himself of an inconvenient figure, already invested with the succession by Marcian (whose daughter Anthemius had married), and could claim the credit for having chosen the Augustus of Rome and restored the unity of the *partes*; in the West, the Senate, after the failure of Majorian and Ricimer's inertia, obtained the guarantee of a massive effort against the Vandals: it was precisely from Rome that the delegations moved with which the negotiations for the appointment began, which occurred in the spring of 467¹³. The image of Ricimer's 'shadow government' is greatly reduced by the examination of these events: if after Majorian's death in 461, he had conducted Rome's military policy with ample margins of autonomy and had been able to represent himself in ways that suggested an approximation of his figure to that of a monarch, his inability to effectively counter Genseric's threats eroded the trust of the senate: in 467, his main point of reference in the *curia*, Decius Bassilius, was by then a close collaborator of Anthemius¹⁴■. The sixteen years in which Ricimer maintained his position as *magister militum praesentis* thus escape a homogeneous framework: his aspiration to act beyond the perimeter of the functions strictly connected to his office ¹⁵■ reached its maximum realization between Majorian and Anthemius. First, in 457, his attempt to assume a leading role in the new imperial government had been frustrated by Majorian's choices, just as later, in 466/467, his ambitions would be forced to retreat in the face of the senate's new orientations. In both cases, it was external events that allowed him to regain ground: the destruction of Majorian's fleet and the failure of Anthemius' military project. It can be stated that, at least in these two circumstances, Ricimer's momentary success was favored by Genseric's political stature.

1 1. ¹² On this aspect, see below, chap. I.

2 2. ¹³ See below, chap. IV.

3 3. ¹⁴ Ibid.

4 4. ¹⁵■ On the problems related to the powers of the *magister militum praesentis*, see below, chap. IX (with references to historiographical orientations).

INTRODUCTIONThe defeat inflicted on the Roman forces by the King of the Vandals constitutes the main cause of the end of Anthemius' government (as had already happened in the case of Majorian). His oriental origins had no bearing on the outcome of his political parabola: indeed, they had positive reflections on his image, especially in Rome.¹⁶ Certainly, the role assumed by the eastern court could arouse fear of a progressive extension of its authority in the West, but this was the price that the Italian ruling classes were willing to pay in exchange for the commitment to strengthen the Roman military presence in the central Mediterranean. Anthemius' origin is the indicator of an ambitious experiment, and the harmony between the two parts of the empire, found after a period of cold relations, is an expression of the vitality of a world that was experimenting with new strategies to counter the snares and multiple problems threatening the integrity of Rome. The year 455 was also this: a moment of rupture that gave rise to a creative phase in the history of the Western Roman Empire. With the death of Aetius and the end of the Theodosian dynasty, the fragility of the imperial government worsened, which, however, did not originate then but descended from the crisis of the age of Stilicho. At that moment, the senatorial aristocracy - which had evident responsibilities in determining that crisis - acted to find a remedy: it did so in a disorganized way, sometimes supporting Ricimer, sometimes favoring - particularly with Majorian and Anthemius - projects that aimed to restore stability to the Roman Empire through the restitution to Rome of the territories lost in Africa and Gaul, and through the centralization, under the direct authority of the Roman emperor, of governmental functions, both civil and military.***The choice of themes for the ten chapters of this volume is based on the intention to combine the analysis of Anthemius' figure with a broader discussion of the Roman West. In the first part, *Between East and West*, three chapters are dedicated to the overall problem of the perception of Greeks in the West, to Anthemius' origins, to the political relations between the two parts of the empire; in the second, *Anthemius in Rome*, Anthemius' settlement and the organization of the imperial hierarchy are studied in close connection with the cultural and religious context of the city of Rome; in the third, *Internal Politics and Military Politics*, the political directions emerging from legislation, the military structure, and the strategies implemented in those years are finally analyzed. This book is part of a larger project, which I am conducting at the Scuola Normale Superiore since 2017, and which simultaneously foresees the publication of a monograph on Anthemius' panegyric. The two works are complementary. I am grateful to the Scuola Normale for having entirely financed the project, to the anonymous reviewers who have read this book, and to the authors who have contributed to its realization.

1 1. 16 See below, chapters V and VI.